



A MUCH-NEEDED VICTORY

The Revolutionary War was not going well for the Americans in the summer of 1777. They had spent the last two years fighting for their independence from Great Britain, and they were losing. The British military's fighting force had many advantages over the Americans' Continental army. British King George III's troops, called redcoats because they wore scarlet woolen jackets, had entered the war well trained and heavily armed. By contrast, the Continental army, commanded by American general George Washington, was a ragtag group of fighters. Washington's men had little military experience and lesser-quality equipment than their British counterparts. Some members of local militias joined the Continental army.

In 1777, American military forces needed a victory that would alter the course of the Revolutionary War with the British in their favor.

The Americans relied on grit and courage, but most of the time, that had not been enough to win battles. American fighters, known as patriots, were often outnumbered and outgunned by the British army. The Americans lost battles they had started off winning. Death on the battlefield was taking a substantial toll on the American troops.

Great Britain controlled New York City and much of the surrounding area and all of eastern Canada. The British Royal Navy was in a strong position, ready to attack anywhere along the Eastern Seaboard. British military commanders felt the king's army was just one crushing victory away from ending the American uprising altogether.

A PLAN TO CRUSH THE REVOLT

Washington's troops had won several battles in the difficult struggle. However, they had not been able to deliver a decisive blow. They needed to prove to possible allies they were up to the task of defeating Great Britain and winning the war. British military leaders were determined to win the war before that could happen. British general John Burgoyne hatched a plan he believed would force the Americans to surrender.

Burgoyne hoped to sever New England from the rest of the American colonies. Under the plan, Burgoyne would lead an army of 8,000 men southward from Quebec, Canada, to Albany, New York.¹ Half of Burgoyne's forces were British troops. The other half was made up of hired German soldiers, called Hessians, and Mohawk American Indians, who supported the British effort. Both groups would operate under Burgoyne's command.

A second British force, led by Colonel Barry St. Leger, would head east through the Mohawk Valley in upstate New York. At the same time, British general William Howe would lead troops north from New York City. The three forces would meet in Albany. There they could smash through the Continental army and gain control of the Hudson

HESSIAN TROOPS

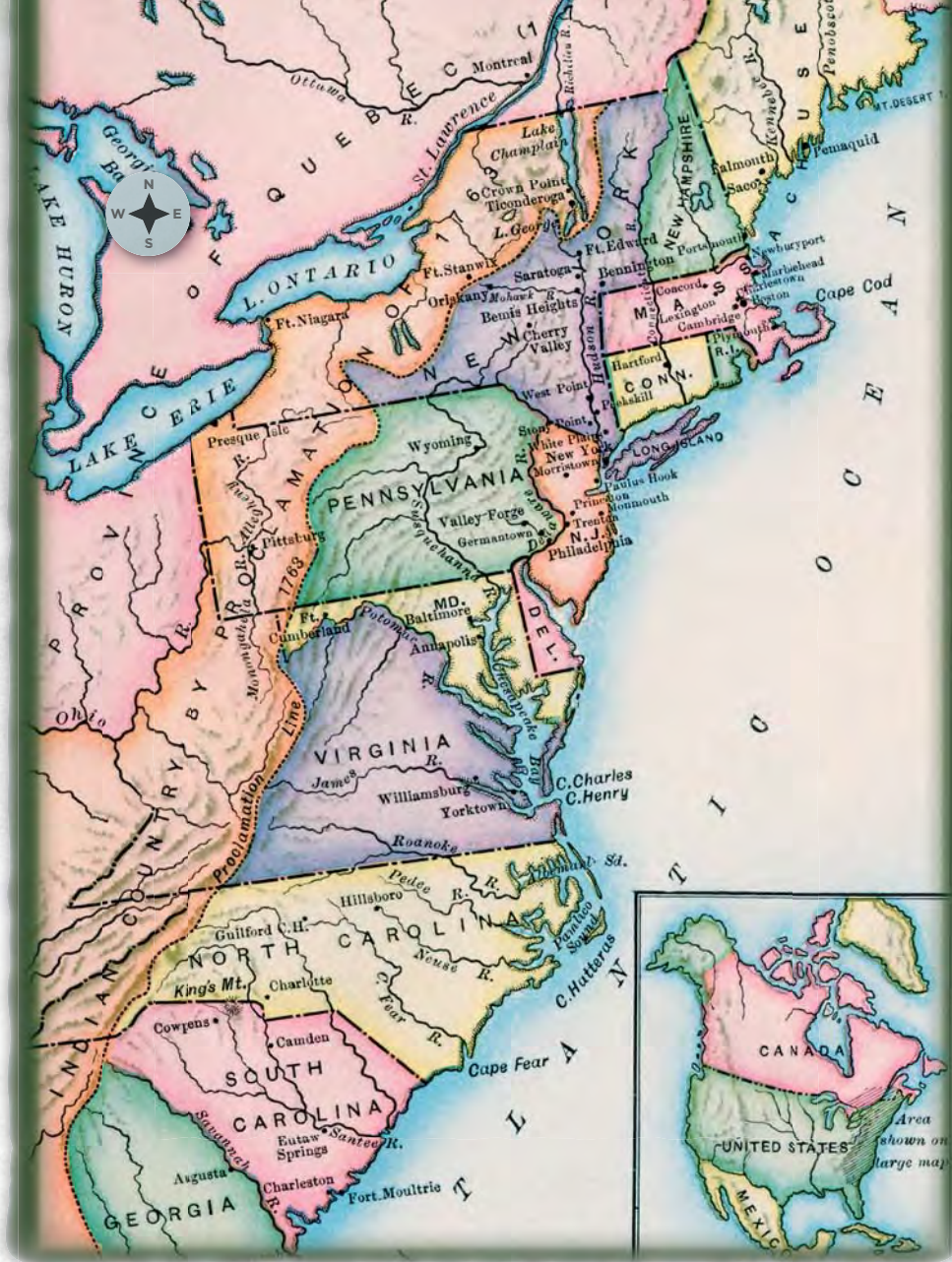
Great Britain needed additional manpower during the Revolutionary War, so it hired men from Germany to serve in the British army. Many of the hired soldiers came from the Hesse region of Germany and were known as Hessians. Approximately 30,000 Germans fought for the British in the American Revolution. More than 12,000 of these men were Hessians.²

River, isolating the four New England colonies from the other nine colonies.

The British saw the New England area, especially Boston, Massachusetts, as the base of operations for revolution supporters. Separating Boston and the rest of New England from the southern colonies would make it impossible for New England patriots to contribute soldiers and supplies to the revolutionary cause. Burgoyne believed this would break the Americans' spirit, ending the rebellion once and for all.

The plan started off well. Burgoyne's troops left Canada in June 1777. By early July, Burgoyne had won an easy victory in upstate New York, seizing Fort Ticonderoga, which had been held by the Americans. Before long, however, the British general's march toward Albany ran into trouble. The countryside was made up of swamps, gullies, and heavy underbrush. The rough terrain slowed Burgoyne's army.

The Continental army was familiar with the landscape. With the help of local militias, the army periodically attacked the British as they trekked through the marshy wilderness. The redcoats suffered losses each time they clashed with the American soldiers.



The American colonies at the time of the Revolutionary War

SETBACKS FOR THE BRITISH

By August, Burgoyne's troops were running low on supplies because of the difficult conditions. He sent a detachment, or smaller group, to round up supplies. Lieutenant Colonel Friedrich Baum commanded the detachment. On August 16, patriot forces clashed with Baum's men in Walloomsac, New York, approximately ten miles (16 km) from Bennington, Vermont. In what became known as the Battle of Bennington, local militias from New Hampshire and Massachusetts killed or captured Baum's entire force, drastically reducing Burgoyne's manpower.

Colonel St. Leger had also faced a major setback earlier in August. On his way to join Burgoyne in Albany, St. Leger had attempted to capture Fort Stanwix. Fort Stanwix was a defensive stronghold for the Americans in the Mohawk River valley region of New York, which was populated by many of Great Britain's Mohawk allies. Initially, St. Leger's men fought the patriots for the fort. But the Continental army refused to give up its position. American reinforcements, led by General Benedict Arnold, held off the British attack.

When Arnold and his men arrived, Arnold spread out his troops. He tricked the British into thinking he was attacking

with a larger force than he actually had. The misinformation scared off many of St. Leger's Mohawk allies, who fled. This convinced St. Leger to order his army to retreat, stopping the British advance to Albany through the Mohawk valley.

Meanwhile, in September, General Howe captured Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, the patriot's capital, before heading to Albany. He did not plan on the strong resistance he received from Washington's troops there. The Americans had to give up Philadelphia, but they delayed Howe. He and his men never made it to Albany. Burgoyne was left alone to carry out his plan to sever New England from the rest of

TRAITOR

Benedict Arnold was one of the early supporters of independence from Great Britain. He fought bravely for the patriots in the war. He rose to the rank of general in the Continental army. After the British abandoned Philadelphia in June 1778, Arnold was named America's military commander of the city. However in 1780, Arnold began giving American military secrets to the British. He was exposed as a traitor in September and joined the British army, where he was made a general. He fought for the British during the rest of the Revolutionary War. After the war, he escaped to England with his family. In the United States today, his name is synonymous with being a traitor.

the colonies. Despite these setbacks, Burgoyne was committed to seeing his plan through.

THE BATTLE OF SARATOGA

The Americans had been paying attention to the movement of the British troops, so they had a good idea of where the redcoats were going. On September 13, Burgoyne's men began crossing the Hudson River near Saratoga, New York, which was less than 40 miles (64 km) north of Albany. Patriot forces, led by General Horatio Gates, were ready for him.

The patriots had dug trenches into the rolling hills of an area known as Bemis Heights. On the morning of September 19, the Americans spotted the British army crossing through an abandoned farm approximately ten miles (16 km) south of Saratoga. The Battle of Saratoga was about to begin.

Gates's troops relentlessly fired on the enemy, stopping many of the redcoats. General Arnold, who had come down from the Mohawk valley to join the fight, led an American regiment that cut off advancing British troops in the middle of the farm. His soldiers inflicted heavy losses on the British, but by the end of the day, Burgoyne's troops had forced the Americans to fall back. The battle had taken a heavy toll on the

British, however. Burgoyne's troops suffered massive losses and were demoralized by the Americans' resolve. Furthermore, the patriots still blocked the road to Albany. The Continental army continued expanding as more troops arrived daily to join the battle.

Burgoyne hoped for reinforcements, but they never arrived. Skirmishes continued for days. Finally, on October 7, the British mounted another attack, which became known as the Battle of Bemis Heights, or the Second Battle of Saratoga. This time, the British were determined to force the Americans from Bemis Heights and gain access to the road to Albany. In the furious fighting that followed, the redcoats suffered heavy losses. By then, Burgoyne had lost more than 3,000 of his original 8,000 men.³ He was surrounded by more than

LONG SHOT

In the Battle of Saratoga, American snipers used American-made long rifles to pick off British troops. Long rifles were much more accurate than other guns used at the time. Long rifles were also light and slender compared to the cumbersome muskets of the day. Skilled marksmen could fire long rifles from a perch in a tree and hit a target more than 200 yards (183 m) away. British soldiers feared the long rifles.

20,000 American troops.⁴ Burgoyne knew he would not be able to sustain his army in this position over the coming winter. Greatly outnumbered by the Americans, Burgoyne surrendered on October 17.

The Americans had their decisive victory. It would help convince France to support the colonies in their fight for independence. The win gave new hope to patriots in all the colonies. The Second Battle of Saratoga may have been a turning point in the Revolutionary War, but the war for independence was far from over.

Burgoyne's surrender to Gates following the Second Battle of Saratoga was an important victory for the Americans.



